

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1098

By Jones J

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Reverend Dr. Bernard Lafayette, Jr.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Reverend Dr. Bernard Lafayette, Jr.; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Bernard Lafayette's life of courage, faith, and unwavering dedication to justice helped shape the course of the American Civil Rights Movement, and his commitment to nonviolent social change inspired generations to pursue equality through peaceful action; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Lafayette emerged as one of the central figures of the Civil Rights Movement of the 1960s, playing a key role in many of the defining events of the struggle for racial equality and voting rights in the United States; and

WHEREAS, as a young seminary student in Nashville in 1960, Dr. Bernard Lafayette joined fellow activists John Lewis, Diane Nash, James Bevel, and others in organizing the historic Nashville sit-in movement, a disciplined campaign of nonviolent protest that challenged segregation at lunch counters and public accommodations and ultimately led to the desegregation of Nashville's downtown commercial district; and

WHEREAS, during this formative period, Dr. Lafayette was deeply influenced by the philosophy and practice of nonviolent resistance, participating in workshops and trainings that prepared activists to confront violence and injustice with courage, discipline, and moral conviction; and

WHEREAS, in April 1960, Dr. Bernard Lafayette joined student leaders from across the South in founding the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee, an organization that quickly became one of the most influential forces of the Civil Rights Movement and played a vital role in organizing grassroots campaigns for justice throughout the region; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Lafayette soon placed himself on the front lines of the movement's most dangerous struggles, joining the Freedom Rides of 1961, in which activists challenged the continued segregation of interstate transportation despite federal court rulings declaring such segregation unlawful; and

WHEREAS, during the Freedom Rides, Dr. Bernard Lafayette and his fellow riders faced brutal violence from white mobs determined to preserve segregation, yet they remained steadfast in their commitment to nonviolence, refusing to retaliate even when attacked and beaten; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Lafayette was arrested in Jackson, Mississippi, for his participation in the Freedom Rides and was imprisoned along with hundreds of other civil rights activists at the notorious Mississippi State Penitentiary at Parchman Farm, where he remained incarcerated for more than a month for his peaceful protest against racial injustice; and

WHEREAS, undeterred by violence, imprisonment, and threats against his life, Dr. Bernard Lafayette committed himself fully to the cause of civil rights and soon undertook some of the most challenging organizing work of the era; and

WHEREAS, in 1962, he became director of the Student Nonviolent Coordinating Committee's Alabama Voter Registration Project and, together with his wife, the civil rights advocate Colia Liddell Lafayette, moved to Selma, Alabama, where they organized local citizens in churches, homes, and community spaces to challenge the systematic denial of voting rights to African Americans; and

WHEREAS, the Lafayettes' patient and courageous organizing efforts in Selma laid the groundwork for the historic Selma-to-Montgomery voting rights campaign, which culminated in the fifty-four-mile march that galvanized national attention and helped lead to the passage of the Voting Rights Act of 1965, one of the most significant civil rights laws in American history; and

WHEREAS, during these years of struggle, Dr. Lafayette endured repeated arrests, brutal attacks, and constant threats to his safety, yet he remained firmly committed to the

philosophy of nonviolence, even in moments of extreme danger, demonstrating extraordinary courage and moral leadership; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Lafayette later became a close associate and trusted lieutenant of the Reverend Dr. Martin Luther King, Jr., working alongside Dr. King in advancing the cause of civil rights and economic justice and helping to organize the Poor People's Campaign, an effort to unite Americans of all races in the fight against poverty and inequality; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Bernard Lafayette was present in Memphis during the sanitation workers' strike that brought Dr. King to the city in 1968, standing alongside his fellow civil rights leaders during one of the most pivotal and tragic moments in the movement's history; and

WHEREAS, following the height of the Civil Rights Movement, Dr. Lafayette devoted his life to preserving and expanding the philosophy of nonviolent social change, dedicating himself to education, leadership development, and the empowerment of future generations; and

WHEREAS, as an educator, minister, and international lecturer, he conducted workshops, seminars, and training programs on nonviolence across the United States and around the world, helping communities address conflict and injustice through peaceful means and equipping new generations with the tools of disciplined activism; and

WHEREAS, through decades of teaching and mentorship, Dr. Bernard Lafayette empowered countless young leaders to carry forward the principles of courage, compassion, and nonviolent resistance that defined the Civil Rights Movement; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Lafayette's life stands as a testament to the transformative power of faith, perseverance, and moral conviction, and his contributions to the struggle for civil rights helped expand democracy and freedom for millions of Americans; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that we should remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Reverend Dr. Bernard Lafayette, Jr., reflecting

fondly upon his impeccable character, his steadfast commitment to nonviolent social change, and his enduring contributions to the Civil Rights Movement and the advancement of justice.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Dr. Lafayette.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.